



# ACCESSIBILITY

Riposte’s base is exceptionally accessible – ink on bone is 15.39:1, more than double what WCAG AA asks. The risk in this system isn’t the base. It’s the accents.

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Full numbers: `color-reference.md` RL-BRAND-001-COLOR-REFERENCE, generated and verified on every build.

## SEC.01

# 1 • THE ONE THING TO KNOW

bone on pink is 3.16:1. bone on teal is 2.27:1.

Both are **fixed brand rules**. Both **fail** WCAG AA for body text. This is not a defect to be fixed by changing the brand – it's a constraint to be respected by using those pairings only where they're legal:

| LEGAL                                              | ILLEGAL                         |
|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| .chip, .pill, SEC.NN numbers                       | Any paragraph                   |
| .spec and .verdict header rows                     | Any list of sentences           |
| 6px top bars, 8px left bars (no text)              | Form labels and help text       |
| Uppercase display at 24px+ or bold 18.66px+        | Captions, footnotes, fine print |
| The .triband footer cell (short uppercase strings) | Links inside body copy          |

WCAG's "AA Large" threshold is **3:1**, and applies at 24px+ regular or 18.66px+ bold. bone on pink (3.16:1) clears it. bone on teal (2.27:1) **does not clear even that** – teal fills may carry short uppercase chrome as a brand convention, but never anything a reader has to parse. Where teal must hold real text, use -teal-deep.

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## THE FIX, WHEN YOU NEED ONE

Every accent has a text-safe deep variant. Same hue, same saturation, lightness dropped until bone clears 4.5:1:

| BRIGHT (FILLS)  | DEEP (TEXT-BEARING)  | BONE ON DEEP |
|-----------------|----------------------|--------------|
| -pink #F0477D   | -pink-deep #D81150   | 4.53:1 ✓ AA  |
| -orange #FE9A0D | -orange-deep #A15E01 | 4.52:1 ✓ AA  |
| -teal #12B795   | -teal-deep #0C7A63   | 4.69:1 ✓ AA  |

Or invert: **ink on marigold is 8.12:1** – the best-contrasting accent pairing in the system, and the reason marigold is the correct fill for .note callouts, warnings, and anything else where the words matter more than the vibe.

## SEC.02

## 2 • ACCENT-COLOURED TEXT ON BONE

The other common trap. Two of the three accents **cannot be text on a bone page**:

|        | ON BONE | VERDICT            |
|--------|---------|--------------------|
| pink   | 3.16:1  | Large/display only |
| orange | 1.90:1  | Never text         |
| teal   | 2.27:1  | Never text         |

A teal heading on a bone page must be `-teal-deep`. A marigold heading must be `-orange-deep` – and at 1.90:1 the bright version is nearly invisible to everyone, not just to low-vision readers.

Use `-accent-text` rather than naming a colour. It resolves correctly per field: `pink-deep` on bone, plain `teal` on ink (6.79:1 – already safe), `ink` on a pink field.

## SEC.03

## 3 • COLOUR IS NEVER THE ONLY SIGNAL

Every state in the system pairs a colour with a **glyph**:

```
✓ pass      teal      .verdict.yes
× fail      pink      .verdict.no
! warning   marigold .verdict.warn / .note
```

This holds for charts too: series are distinguished by fill **and** by label, direct-labelled where possible rather than relying on a legend.

The accent rotation (pink → marigold → teal across cards) is decorative, not se-

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mantic. If a reader can't tell the three apart, they lose nothing – the content is identical. Never encode meaning in "the pink one".

## SEC.04

## 4 • FOCUS

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CSS

```
:focus-visible { outline: 3px solid var(--focus-ring); outline-offset: 2px; }
```

3px, not 2 – a 2px ring is indistinguishable from the system's structural 2px borders. The 2px offset separates it from the element's own border.

`-focus-ring` is pink on bone (3.16:1 against bone – clears the 3:1 non-text UI threshold) and teal on ink (6.79:1). **Never remove the outline.** The brand has no soft alternative to fall back on; there's no glow, no shadow, no colour shift subtle enough to substitute.

## SEC.05

## 5 • MOTION

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Motion is already minimal – 120/150/250ms, plain easing, no scroll-triggered fades, no parallax. The stylesheet still honours the preference:

CSS

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {  
  .marquee .track { animation: none; }  
  *, *::before, *::after {  
    animation-duration: .001ms !important;  
    animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;  
    transition-duration: .001ms !important;  
  }  
}
```

```
.cta:hover, .btn:hover, button:hover { transform: none; }  
}
```

The `.marquee` ticker is the only continuous animation in the system, and it's the first thing to stop. Hover pops lose their `translate` but keep their colour inversion, so the state change is still visible.

## SEC.06 6 • STRUCTURE

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The visual system leans hard on borders and uppercase – neither of which conveys anything to a screen reader. So:

- ▶ **Uppercase is `text-transform`, never typed.** Type Process, style it uppercase. A screen reader announcing P-R-O-C-E-S-S as letters is a real failure mode, and text typed in caps also can't be searched or translated properly.
- ▶ **SEC.03 chips and DOC NO. marks are decorative chrome.** If they're not part of the document outline, mark them `aria-hidden="true"` so the heading reads as its title, not as SEC.03 THE COUNTER-ATTACK.
- ▶ **Glyph bullets come from `::before`,** so they're not in the accessible name. That's correct – ▶ shouldn't be announced. But ✓ and × in `.verdict` **do** carry meaning, so pair them with visually-hidden text (Pass:) or an `aria-label` on the list.
- ▶ **`.checker` and `.harlequin` bands are pure decoration.** `aria-hidden="true"`.
- ▶ **Heading levels follow the document, not the type scale.** A `-text-h3`-sized heading can be an `<h2>`. Size is a style; level is structure.

## SEC.07

## 7 • TYPE SIZES

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Body copy is 15px (16px on the homepage) – at or just below the conventional 16px baseline. Monospace at 15px reads larger than a proportional face at 15px because the x-height and character width are both generous, but:

- ▶ **Never go below 14px for prose.** `-text-md` (14px) is the floor for anything sentence-shaped.
- ▶ The 10-12px steps are for uppercase labels only, where tracking keeps them legible.
- ▶ Everything scales with browser zoom and `rem`-based user settings; nothing is locked to viewport units alone (`clamp()` always has a `px` floor).
- ▶ `-webkit-text-size-adjust: 100%` prevents iOS from silently inflating text.

## SEC.08

## 8 • PRINT

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Print styles drop to true black on white, hide the decorative bands, and underline links. Structural rules go to **1.5pt minimum** – below 1pt, a 2px screen rule disappears at press and the entire visual structure with it. See `08-print.md`<sup>RL-BRAND-001-PRINT</sup>.

## 9 • THE AUTOMATED CHECK

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`scripts/build.js` fails the build if:

- ▶ a `-deep` accent stops clearing 4.5:1 against bone
- ▶ `ink` on `orange` stops clearing 4.5:1
- ▶ any `border-radius` other than 0 appears
- ▶ any `box-shadow` gains a blur radius
- ▶ `tokens.json` and `riposte-brand.css` disagree on a hex value
- ▶ `riposte.ase` stops round-tripping

It does **not** check your markup. Contrast maths is automatable; whether you put a paragraph on a teal fill is not. That one's on you.

BASH

```
| node scripts/build.js --check
```

SOURCE docs/07-accessibility.md SHA e9635e34129f BUILT 2026-08-15